

Session 4: Becoming Moses

Key Takeaways

- Moses' naming foreshadows his role as deliverer, but it also embraces the ambiguity of his identity.
- When God identifies himself, he also solidifies Moses' identity.

Naming Moses

Moses' name presents readers with several interpretive possibilities. In Hebrew, Moses means "one who draws out." This speaks of both his deliverance by the hand of Pharaoh's daughter and his role as God's chosen deliverer. However, in Egyptian, Moses means "son of ..." potentially drawing attention to ambiguity surrounding Moses' identity.

Who Is Moses?

The beginning chapters of Exodus wrestle with questions about Moses' identity. How is he identified in the first two chapters? How does Moses' commissioning clarify his identity? Ultimately, God speaks the words that settle the questions about Moses' identity. "I am the God of your father, God of Abraham, God of Isaac, and God of Jacob" ([Exod. 3:6](#)).

Moses and the Betrothal Scene Pattern

"M. expands on the five-element betrothal type-scene identified by Robert Alter in the OT. He identifies seven additional typical elements that help constitute a larger betrothal journey narrative in which the betrothal type-scene is situated. The full pattern comprises the following elements: (1) a groom-to-be travels to a foreign land; (2) he meets (a) young woman/women at a well; (3) someone draws water; (4) the suitor gives a gift or performs an ingratiating service; (5) the suitor reveals his identity; (6) someone rushes with news of his arrival to the woman's family; (7) the family responds with a greeting/invitation; (8) a betrothal is arranged; (9) the suitor resides with the woman's family; (10) the suitor returns home; (11) he is received by his kin at journey's end; and (12) the suitor resides with his kin. Next, M. shows how the pattern is creatively adapted in various stories in OT, Intertestamental, and NT literature, including narratives about Isaac, Jacob, Moses, Ruth, Saul, David, the entire story of Tobit, and the encounter of Jesus and the Samaritan woman in the Fourth Gospel. Interpretation of these narratives is informed by recognition not only of their conformity to the pattern but also their innovative use of it."

Abstracted by: William J. Urbrock for *Old Testament Abstracts*

For further discussion of this topic, see Martin, Michael W. (2008). "Betrothal Journey Narratives." *Catholic Biblical Quarterly* 70. 505-23.

Moses' Hybrid Identity

For further discussion of Moses' hybrid identity, see Mbuvi, Amanda. "Multicultural Moses: Reexamining and Icon." *Biblical Archaeology Review Volume 45, (no. 4-5)*. 16-18.

Reflection Question

How does Moses' commissioning clarify his identity?